

The Wall

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Independent

Abstract

The wall does not move. This is its function. Without resistance that holds, there is no encounter, no failure, no adjustment, no skill. The wall is not the obstacle to learning. It is the condition of it.

A wall that yields is not a wall. It is a suggestion. Practice against suggestions produces fluency. Fluency is not skill. Fluency is the ability to do something that has not yet required you to fail.

The wall holds. The wall is what requires failure. The failure is what teaches.

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The mathematician at the wall returns to the same problem across years. The problem does not get easier. She gets better.

The distinction is important. The wall does not change. The practitioner changes. The wall's resistance is what makes the change possible.

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What does the wall do?

It shows you what you do not yet have. Each failure is information: this approach was not adequate. The information is specific. It is not general. It points at something.

The practitioner who has failed at this wall enough times knows the shape of the wall. Not abstractly. The way a hand knows the shape of a tool: through having used it, been wrong about it, adjusted.

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The shape of the wall is tacit.

It cannot be fully described. It can be learned only by failing at this wall. The failures that teach the shape are not transferable. Someone else's failures at this wall teach you that there is a wall. They do not teach you the shape.

The shape is acquired by your body in your failures.

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AI does not meet walls. It meets data. The data is the record of others meeting walls. The record describes the wall from outside.

A description of the wall is not the wall. The wall is what you feel when you are against it. The feeling is not in the description. The description is useful. It is not the thing.

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The walls have not moved. Riemann's wall. The wall of the NS equations. The wall at the archimedean place.

They are the same walls. They hold. The skill they require has not been acquired.

This is not failure. This is the situation. The walls that hold are the ones worth meeting.

References

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